

Features

Video Features

The maximum resolution of the TV-Tuner determines the sharpness and detail of the image. The maximum resolution of three of the TV-Tuners in this category is a healthy 1280 x 1024, which is as high as what most 17-inch monitors can handle. Only the Tech-Com SSD-TV-715 has a resolution of 640 x 480, which is low by any standards. If you're using an LCD monitor, this is a concern, because LCDs display fuzzy images when not using their native hardware resolution. The other three TV-Tuners can handle as many as eight different resolutions, one of which would surely be that of your LCD.

Picture-In-Picture is present on the AVerMedia AVerTV Box7 and the Tech-Com SSD-TV-722. Using this feature, you can continue working at your PC, while the TV window will be perched unobtrusively in a corner of the Desktop.



AVerMedia AVerTV Box7
Bet You Can't Get Anything Better Than This!

I/O Ports

Being external set-top tuners, these did not lack any of the necessary inputs such as S-Video and Composite. The Zebronics has a port that looks like the USB port, but we found it's there to accept a connection via the AV cable from an external AV source such as a DVD player. The AVerMedia AVerTV Box7 even has a headphone socket.

The Remote Control

The remote controls accompanying these TV-Tuners are very much like those of a regular television set. This was because of the fact that these tuners are functionally very much like a TV set, except for the display and speakers, of course. Some additional features such as Picture-In-Picture—in the case of the AVerMedia AVerTV

Box7 and the Tech-Com SSD-TV-722—can be controlled using their remotes. The Tech-Com SSD-TV-715 has a Menu button to access functions such as inbuilt games, which are of the most elementary kind.

Cables And Accessories

These TV-Tuners are placed between the computer's display adapter and the monitor, if you're using a PC. If you wish to switch between PC and TV on-the-fly, the tuners connect to the monitor and also receive input from the display adapter. An audio cable is another accessory to get audio from the unit to the sound card's Line-In. The Tech-Com SSD-TV-722 comes with an MMI (MultiMedia Interface) cable, while the Zebronics comes with an AV cable to get video and audio inputs from external sources such as a DVD player. This way, you can play a DVD without the need for a PC.

Looks and Build

The AVerMedia AVerTV Box7 is the most rugged, and it comes with a stand that allows it to stand upright. This not only adds to visual elegance, it also conserves desktop space. The Zebronics has a better build than the Tech-Coms. Overall, these look dull compared to the Box7.

Performance

Ease of Setup and Use

Setting up these TV-Tuners is, again, extremely easy. The accompanying manuals have easy instructions in any case. Using them is as easy as using your TV set. Of all of them, the AVerMedia AVerTV Box7 is the easiest to use.

The Field Tests

We had high expectations from these as compared to TV-Tuners of the other categories, because these can be disconnected from the PC and its interfering radiation. True to our expectations, these tuners performed remarkably better.

The AVerMedia AVerTV Box7 was ahead of the pack, detecting 88 channels. The Tech-Com

Digital Television

Digital Television is a telecommunication system that uses digital instead of analogue signals to broadcast moving pictures and sounds. It employs digitally modulated data which is compressed and scrambled, and requires specially-designed set-top boxes and televisions, or a digital PC TV-Tuner.

This type of television broadcast has several advantages over analogue, the immediate one being that digital channels take up less bandwidth, so it is possible to squeeze more channels in a given bandwidth. A greater availability of bandwidth is also useful for special services such as multicasting (multiple programs on the same channel) and EPG (electronic program guide). This is also used to deliver television with higher resolution—HDTV—which delivers not only superior image quality, but also multi-channel audio. HDTV broadcasts have some problems such as slight deterioration of image quality because of MPEG-2 compression, but these will soon be ironed out.

Digital Television is very reluctantly being accepted by several countries, the primary reason being the heavy cost of the

necessary infrastructure. The consumer has to upgrade his TV and recording equipment, while the government has to invest a considerable amount to upgrade its broadcast systems. Even a developed country like UK will switch over from analogue to digital only in phased stages starting from 2008 to 2012.

Currently, only The Netherlands has completed the switchover to digital broadcasting, but this is attributed to a large extent to the fact that over 90 per cent of households receive television over cable in the analogue format, thus leaving less than 10 per cent to be affected by the switchover.

India adopted DVB-T or Terrestrial Digital Video Broadcast, a digital broadcast standard, in 1999. India switched off analogue terrestrial broadcast and has been broadcasting terrestrial channels in this way ever since. There are a few TV-Tuners that sport DVB-T receiving capabilities, but don't rush for these yet—this service is only available in four metros thus far. The number of channels is also limited; in Mumbai, you can view DD1, DD2, DD Sports, DD Bharti, and DD Sahyadri.